

FOH ↔ Kitchen Briefing Sheet

The handshake between front and back. New chefs and new servers read this on day one. Prevents most pass-side friction in independent restaurants.

1 Problem dishes — manage at the point of order, not at the point of return

Dishes where the kitchen's spec and the customer's intuition disagree. FOH flags these **at the table**, before the order goes in.

STANDARD SERVER LINE

"Just to flag — the [dish] is served [doneness] as standard. That's how the kitchen recommends it. Would you like it that way, or shall I check what else they can do?"

DISH	KITCHEN SPEC	SERVER-SIDE NOTE
Lamb	Pink (medium-rare)	Well-done not offered; only with explicit warning of texture
Steak (rare / blue)	Cold-ish middle	Always flag at order — set expectation
Tuna	Pink in the middle = the dish	Not "undercooked" — confirm pink with diner
Burger	[Your spec]	If menu = medium minimum, no well-done
[Add your own]	[Spec]	[Server line]
[Add your own]	[Spec]	[Server line]

2 Allergen rule — written only. No verbal handovers, ever.

If it's not on the ticket, the dish doesn't go out. If FOH tries to tell the kitchen verbally, the kitchen stops service for 10 seconds and asks for the order to be re-input with the allergen tag. **No exceptions** for regulars where "we already know", for "the customer just told me", or for "we're slammed." Assumed knowledge is where serious incidents happen.

The 14 UK regulated allergens — every one must appear on the kitchen ticket automatically, not because the server remembered:

☐ Celery
 ☐ Cereals (gluten)
 ☐ Crustaceans
 ☐ Eggs
 ☐ Fish
 ☐ Lupin
 ☐ Milk
 ☐ Molluscs
 ☐ Mustard
 ☐ Tree nuts
 ☐ Peanuts
 ☐ Sesame
 ☐ Soya
 ☐ Sulphites

3 86 protocol — when a dish runs out

When kitchen knows: tell FOH within **60 seconds**. Not at the next ticket. Not at the end of service. Immediately.

Method: [pick your team's signal]

☐ Verbal call
 ☐ Whiteboard tally
 ☐ POS strike-through

STANDARD TABLE LINE

"Just to flag — the [dish] has sold out tonight. Here's what we'd recommend in its place: [alt dish]. Or anything else from the menu that takes your eye."

4 Service-pace signal — "we're behind on mains"

When the kitchen is 10+ minutes behind on mains, FOH needs to know **without anyone yelling across the pass**. Pick one signal and use it consistently. Both sides know what it means.

☐ Chalk number on the pass
 ☐ Flag on ticket rail
 ☐ Whiteboard delay column
 ☐ Verbal cue: "we're on +10"

Our signal: _____

5 "Let me check with the chef" — when FOH defers

When a customer wants a modification the kitchen will probably refuse, **FOH defers instead of over-promising**. Better to come back with "no" than to send a yes the kitchen won't honour.

STANDARD SERVER LINE

"Let me check with the chef on that — I'll come back to you in 2 minutes." (Then go ask. Don't guess.)

Defaults the kitchen tends to refuse — agree these in advance so FOH stops asking each time:

- Major recipe rewrites mid-service (e.g. "can you make the pasta sauce without cream and add prawns?")
- Off-menu requests on busy services
- Substitutions that break a dish's structure
- Doneness requests outside the kitchen's standard (see Section 1)

The owner's job in chronic friction is to fix the system that produced it — not to referee individual incidents. If you find yourself mediating the same incident more than twice, the system is broken, not the people.